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Sounds and Alphabet

The sound inventory of Skiri Pawnee is one of the smallest among the languages of North America and, in fact, the world. It has nine consonants and three vowels. The vowels occur in two varieties, long and short, so there are actually fifteen phonemes, which are given in tables 2 and 3.

Consonants

The consonants of Skiri, arranged by manner and place of articulation, are in table 2.

Table 2. Skiri Pawnee Consonants

		Labial	**Alveolar**	**Velar**	**Laryngeal**
Obstruents	Stops: voiceless	*p*	*t*	*k*	*ʔ*
	Affricate: voiceless		*c*		
	Fricatives: voiceless		*s*		*h*
Sonorants	Glide and Tap: voiced	*w*	*r*		

Of the preceding consonants, the three stops (*p*, *t*, *k*) and the affricate (*c*) are always voiceless and unaspirated. Pronunciation of the stops is the same as it is for their counterparts in English when they follow *s* in word initial position, as in English *spot*, *stop*, and *skit*. The affricate *c* is the only consonant that has consistent phonetic variants: one is apico-alveolar [ts], as in the final sound of English *hats*. It occurs before consonants and in word-final position, as in *riictaaruʔ*, pronounced [riits-taaruʔ], 'intestines' and *apiic*, pronounced [əpiits], 'on the other side of water', respectively. The other variant is lamino-palatal [č], as in the final sound of English *watch*, that occurs when *c* precedes a vowel, as in *capaat* [čəpaat].

Two consonants are voiceless fricatives (*s*, *h*). Most Skiri speakers pronounce *s* like it is in English, but some speakers pronounce it farther back, sounding more like English [š], written *sh*, as in *ship*. The laryngeal *h* is also like its equivalent in English, but it has a slightly breathier variant that occurs before other consonants, as in *kuhku* 'pig'.

The two sonorants (*w*, *r*) are voiced. Bilabial *w* is pronounced as it is in English. Apico-alveolar *r* is usually a tap like its counterpart in Spanish, as in *pero* 'but'.

However, in word-initial position many speakers frequently pronounce the sound as a nasal [n] and some speakers even pronounce it occasionally as a lateral [l].

Vowels

Skiri vowels are presented in table 3.

Table 3. Skiri Pawnee Vowels

	Front	Central	Back
High	*i, ii*		*u, uu*
Low		*a, aa*	

Two high vowels (*i*, *ii*) are front and unrounded, while two others (*u*, *uu*) are back and rounded. With some speakers the long back vowel *uu* is pronounced slightly more fronted, but not as front as a central vowel. The mid-low vowels (*a*, *aa*) are central, unrounded. Each of the three basic vowels varies in pronunciation between tense and lax variants:

- High front *i* is lax [ɪ] (the vowel of English *mitt*), as in *istu* [ɪstu] 'again' and *pitku* [pɪtku] 'two'.
- High back *u* similarly varies between tense [u] (the vowel of English *flute*), as in *iksuʔ* [ɪksuʔ] 'hand', and lax [ʊ] (the vowel of English *put*), as in *tiʔukut* [tiʔukʊt] 'it dropped'.
- Mid-low central *a* varies between lower [a] (the first vowel of English *father*), as in *rahwa* [rahwa] 'captive' and higher [ə] (the vowel of English *but*), as in *akaʔ* [əkəʔ] 'your grandmother'.

The vowels that are written doubled (*ii*, *uu*, *aa*) are long in duration and are always tense [ii, uu, aa], as in *piita* [piitə] 'man', *uusuʔ* [uusuʔ] 'hair', and *aaruʔ* [aaruʔ] 'tooth'. Generally, long vowels are distinctly long, and there is no ambiguity in perceiving the difference between a long vowel and its short counterpart. However, frequently when a long vowel precedes the laryngeal *h* or a syllable-final, or coda, consonant, spectrographic measurements of multiple tokens show that vocalic length varies along a relatively wide temporal spread, where some tokens are in or near the high range for short vowels, while many fall within the high range for long vowels, but most are in the mid range. There are also alternations in vocalic length in pairs of verbal prefixes; for example, the plural prefix *raar-* is sometimes *raar-/raah-* and other times *rar-/rah-*. Similarly, the descriptive stem *taakaar* 'be white' occurs in two forms, *-taakaa* and *-taka*, when it is the second element of a noun compound, as in *cahikstaakaa* 'white man' (> *cahiks* 'person; human') in contrast to *atikataka* 'navy bean' (> *atik* 'bean'). This alternation occurs frequently, but the difference in vowel length is not predictable. Another example is the dependent noun *asaa-* 'horse; dog',

which occurs in some compounds as *asa-*, illustrated by the following nouns: *asawiita* 'male horse', *asataakaa* 'white horse', and *asaapahat* 'bay horse'.

Stress is not phonemic in Skiri and hence is not marked on words. (Phonetic forms in entries do, however, have accented syllables marked.) There are certain accentual patterns that recur—such as a tendency to give more emphasis to an initial syllable, or to the syllable following it if the vowel of the first syllable is short and that of the second syllable is long; and to similarly accent the antipenultimate or, less frequently, penultimate syllable—but most patterns are ultimately variable.

Skiri Alphabet

The phonemic symbols presented in the preceding two tables comprise the Skiri alphabet. Since only two consonant and three vowel phonemes have phonetic variants, the alphabet is essentially phonetic and enables the user to pronounce words correctly with greater confidence. Nevertheless, in the dictionary a phonetic version of both fully formed words and morphemes that are headwords is given in each entry to aid the reader in correct pronunciation.

In the Skiri-to-English section of the dictionary, the alphabetical arrangement of Skiri entry heads follows the basic arrangement of English: *a*, *aa*, *c*, *h*, *i*, *ii*, *k*, *p*, *r*, *s*, *t*, *u*, *uu*, *w*.

Glottal stops (ʔ) occur in only two environments:

- between vowels, where they keep separate vowels in a sequence distinct (e.g., *riʔaat* 'summer', *kaaʔata* 'upland plover'), and
- in word-final position following a vowel, where, among other functions, they serve primarily to distinguish non-subordinate imperfective verb forms (with a final glottal stop) from subordinate forms (without a glottal stop), as in *tiwaktiikuʔ* 'he is announcing' and *rakuwaktiku* 'for him to be announcing'.

Because glottal stop does not occur in word-initial position and does not differentiate lexical meanings, it is treated as a null element in alphabetization.

Speaker Variation

Based on her field studies in the 1930s, Gene Weltfish (1937:v) wrote that the dialectal differences between Skiri and South Band were already beginning to level and were "likely to disappear in the not distant future as there is a tendency on the part of speakers of both dialects to merge differences." That leveling of differences, however, did not occur as Weltfish forecast, at least not in the speech of those Skiris who contributed to this study from 1965 onward. Every Skiri and South Band speaker with whom I collaborated was conscious of the contrasting phonological and lexical differences between their dialects and, indeed, rarely if ever mixed them. Nearly everyone expressed strong pride in speaking their own dialect. In texts, only one Skiri speaker represented here, Harry Mad Bear, would occasionally use the vowel *e*, a

South Band sound, rather than *i* in certain words—for example, *reesaaruʔ* for *riisaaruʔ* 'chief' and *he* for *hi* 'and'—but he never did that in other contexts, as when recording vocabulary.

Not only was the speech of late-twentieth-century Skiri speakers uniform, but their speech does not seem to have differed significantly from that of Roaming Scout, whose recordings document the language a century earlier.

The Cluster *kt*

One sound change characterizing Skiri is the assimilation of *k* to *t* in the consonant cluster *kt*, which becomes geminate *tt*. This sound change is documented in the Roaming Scout texts, where nearly 70 percent of *kt* clusters are *tt*. Murie, in contrast, as well as the Skiri speakers with whom Lesser and Weltfish worked in the late 1920s and 1930s, consistently had geminate *tt*. In the 1960s and 1970s, all of the speakers with whom I collaborated also always had *tt*, except for Mrs. Pratt, whose speech consistently had *kt*. There were several lexical items that she pronounced with a geminate *tt*, but they were clearly exceptions. When she repeated the sound-recorded speech of other Skiri speakers, she was oblivious to the articulation of geminate *tt* clusters, repeating them consistently as *kt*, even when I remarked on the difference.

Based on all available data, the *kt* to *tt* sound change was an innovation in Skiri that, in the late nineteenth century, was apparently in the last stage of flux, as illustrated by Roaming Scout's retention of *kt* in a minority of instances. By the early twentieth century, however, the change to *tt* seems to have become complete, since recorded speech in the 1920s and, later, in the second half of the twentieth century consistently has *tt*. Why Mrs. Pratt's speech did not conform to that of other Skiri speakers, including that of Gerty Clark, her aunt, in this one pervasive feature is not clear. One explanation may be that, married to a South Band speaker, she adopted his usage, reinforced by other South Band speakers with whom she socialized. Mitigating that explanation, however, is her totally consistent use of all other features distinguishing Skiri. In this dictionary forms are written with *kt* rather than *tt* in conformance with Mrs. Pratt's usage throughout our collaboration, but users should realize that all other twentieth-century Skiri speakers replaced *kt* clusters with *tt*.

Other Sound Differences

Other systematic phonetic differences between Roaming Scout's speech and that of twentieth-century speakers are:

- The older Skiri interrogative form *kirikii* 'what' is generally contracted to *kikii* in contemporary speech.
- The contemporary imperfective distributive form of the verb *aar* 'to become' is *waahi* (*waa-* DIST + *aar* 'do' + *-i* IMPF), whereas Roaming Scout frequently pro-

nounces it as *waari*. In South Band and Arikara the forms are *waahri* and *waahnu*, respectively.

- The verbal prefix sequence *ut-* PREV/BEN + *uks-* AOR/JUSS is realized as *icuks* in Roaming Scout's speech (as it is in South Band), whereas contemporary Skiri speakers consistently say *ucuks-*.
- The prefixal sequence *si-* DU + *ar-* EV, that is, *siʔah-*, which contemporary Skiri speakers generally contract to *siih-*, was not contracted by Roaming Scout.